D02 · Planning Maturity & Digital Transformation

02 · Spreadsheet-to-IBP transition roadmap

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1 WHAT IT IS

A spreadsheet-to-IBP transition roadmap sequences the move off spreadsheets onto an integrated planning platform as a process and capability change first and a technology change second — redesigning the broken process before automating it — so the platform amplifies a sound process instead of cementing the dysfunction the spreadsheets were hiding.

2 WHY IT MATTERS

Brynjolfsson & Hitt 2000 **(Brynjolfsson & Hitt, 2000 — peer-reviewed)** showed that the productivity return on information technology comes overwhelmingly from the complementary organizational and process changes around it, not from the technology itself — firms that buy the system without redesigning the work capture little of the promised value. Applied to planning, this is the spreadsheet-to-IBP trap: a lift-and-shift that rebuilds the existing broken process inside an expensive platform automates the dysfunction rather than removing it. The ROI never arrives, the planners do not trust the output, and the parallel spreadsheets quietly return — now alongside a platform that cost millions. The cost is doubled: **the platform investment plus the unchanged process it failed to fix**, with credibility for the next transformation spent as well.

3 HOW IT IS DONE

1. **Redesign the process before selecting the platform.** Fix the broken process — the missing supply-balancing step, the unreconciled financial bridge — on paper first. Automating a sound process amplifies it; automating a broken one cements it. The sequence is process, then platform, never the reverse.
2. **Resist the lift-and-shift.** Do not rebuild the existing spreadsheets one-for-one inside the platform. The spreadsheets encode workarounds for process and data gaps; replicating them imports the gaps into the new system and guarantees the ROI never materializes.
3. **Fix the data foundation in parallel.** A platform fed the same ungoverned data produces the same untrusted output, faster. The data architecture and master-data work is a prerequisite for the transition, not a later phase — the platform will expose every data gap the spreadsheets papered over.
4. **Phase the rollout against maturity, not the licence.** Sequence the deployment to the capability the organization can absorb — demand planning before integrated S&OP before full IBP — rather than switching on every module because it was purchased. Adoption, not activation, is the measure of progress.
5. **Build planner capability alongside the platform.** The transition changes the planner's job from spreadsheet mechanic to exception manager. Without the skills and the role redefinition, the platform is operated at the level of the spreadsheet it replaced. Capability is a complementary investment, not a training afterthought.
6. **Retire the spreadsheets deliberately.** Set explicit criteria for decommissioning each parallel spreadsheet and hold to them. A transition that tolerates indefinite parallel spreadsheets has not transitioned — it has added a platform to the cost of the old way of working.

> **WORKED EXAMPLE — ILLUSTRATIVE**
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> A company deployed a major IBP platform by replicating its existing spreadsheet model — **baseline: $4M+ implementation, no process redesign, planners back on parallel Excel within six months, ROI unrealized**. It restarted with a process redesign first, a data-foundation track, phased adoption, and planner role redefinition. Results: **the redesigned process closed the supply-balancing and financial-bridge gaps, planner trust shifted to the platform, parallel spreadsheets were decommissioned on schedule, and the ROI case finally held** — because the process change, not the software, was treated as the transformation.

IN PRACTICE

Process redesign as the first phase

Make the explicit first phase of any IBP program a process redesign, signed off before platform configuration begins. The redesigned process is the specification the platform should implement; configuring the platform to mirror the old process is building the wrong thing well.

Data foundation as a parallel prerequisite

Run the master-data and data-architecture work as a prerequisite track, not a later phase. The platform will surface every data gap immediately; addressing data after go-live means launching the platform into the same distrust that kept the spreadsheets alive.

Phase adoption to absorbable capability

Sequence the rollout to what the organization can actually adopt, measuring adoption rather than module activation. A phased path that builds capability at each step beats a big-bang switch-on that activates functionality no one is ready to use.

Decommission spreadsheets on explicit criteria

Define and enforce the criteria for retiring each parallel spreadsheet. Tolerating indefinite shadow spreadsheets signals — and entrenches — distrust of the platform; deliberate decommissioning is how the transition is actually completed rather than merely launched.

WHAT YOU WOULD USE

IBP PLATFORMS / TRANSITION ENABLEMENT

SAP IBP / o9 / Kinaxis — enterprise IBP platforms — Full integrated planning platforms that are the destination of the transition. **(SAP, o9, Kinaxis — vendor)** The right target when the process and data work has been done first; powerful amplifiers of a sound process, and equally powerful entrenchers of a broken one.

Blue Yonder / Anaplan — planning platforms — Capable integrated and connected-planning platforms suited to a phased transition off spreadsheets. **(Blue Yonder, Anaplan — vendor)** A strong fit where flexibility in the rollout sequence and modeling matters during the migration.

Transition / change-management specialists — Implementation partners and change-management tools focused on adoption and process redesign rather than configuration alone. **(specialized vendors — vendor)** The vertical option when the binding risk is adoption and capability, which is where most IBP programs actually fail.

For operations that don't need a platform yet — A redesigned process run with disciplined spreadsheets and a clean data layer first — proving the process works before buying the platform to scale it. Many organizations are not yet mature enough to benefit from IBP; fixing the process on the tooling they have is the honest, cheaper first step.

4 SO WHAT

Operations that redesign the process and fix the data before deploying IBP get a platform that amplifies a sound process; operations that lift-and-shift their spreadsheets get an expensive system running the old dysfunction, and the parallel Excel returns within the year. The platform is never the transformation — it is the amplifier. Buying the tool first is the most expensive and most common way to discover that maturity was never about the software.

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